

TOMATOES *Lycopersicon esculentum*

With flavorful, attractive fruits that range from tiny, currantlike types to huge, fleshy, beefsteak varieties, in colors as diverse as, pink, red, yellow, maroon, and even purple, it is no wonder that the easy-to-grow tomato is loved by gardeners. A wide range of varieties are available as seed, but young plants are also widely sold. These are valuable for gardeners without the warm conditions needed to raise seedlings.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Sow seed in early spring, ensuring a temperature of between 64–77°F (18–25°C). Good, sturdy growth depends on ample warmth and light; crowded plants become elongated and hard to handle later. As soon as they are large enough, seedlings should be set out into individual containers and grown on either in a greenhouse or outdoors. Containers, filled with fertile potting media, will support good crops.

For outdoor tomatoes, plant out only once the danger of frost has passed, after hardening off. A warm, sunny, sheltered site is essential outdoors. Mix a 2 in (5 cm) layer of rotted organic manure or compost and balanced fertilizer into the soil.



Support vine tomatoes with stakes.

CROP CARE

Water plants during dry periods. Tomatoes are self-fertile but may need shaking to effect pollination.

Bush tomatoes need no special treatment—each shoot ends with flowers and therefore will not grow very long. With many such shoots, bush tomatoes require minimal staking. Vine tomato flowers grow out from the stem.